NOTE 02 - TACTICS VS TECHNIQUES

The one-line difference

- A Tactic is the WHY - the adversary's goal or objective at that moment.
- A Technique is the HOW - the method used to reach that goal.

Think of it like a burglary:

	Tactic (goal)	Technique (method)
Burglar	Get inside the house	Pick the back-door lock
Attacker	Gain initial access to the network	Spearphishing attachment

Tactics sit across the columns of the ATT&CK matrix. Techniques sit inside the columns, and each technique is numbered with a T-ID (for example `T1059`), with sub-techniques numbered further (`T1059.001`). Techniques are never tied to one tactic only - the same technique can serve several goals, which is why some techniques appear under more than one column.

Side-by-side comparison

Aspect	Tactic	Technique
Question answered	Why / what is the objective	How / what does the attacker do
Matrix position	Column header	Row inside the column
Identifier	Short name only, no ID	`T` ID (e.g. `T1059`) and sub-technique ID
Count in Enterprise	Around a dozen objectives	Hundreds of techniques and sub-techniques
Example	Execution	Command and Scripting Interpreter (T1059)
Used in reporting for	Describing attacker intent and progress	Describing the detection and the evidence
Changes over time	Rarely changes	Added, updated and refined frequently
Detected by	Not directly detectable - it is a goal	Detectable through telemetry and rules

Enterprise tactics with an example technique each

#	Tactic	What the attacker wants	Example technique (with ID)
1	Reconnaissance	Learn about the target before attacking	T1595 Active Scanning - port scanning the public IP range
2	Initial Access	Get a foothold inside the network	T1566.001 Phishing: Spearphishing Attachment
3	Execution	Run attacker-controlled code	T1059.001 Command and Scripting Interpreter: PowerShell
4	Persistence	Keep access after reboot or logoff	T1547.001 Registry Run Keys / Startup Folder
5	Privilege Escalation	Move from a normal user to admin / SYSTEM	T1068 Exploitation for Privilege Escalation
6	Defense Evasion	Avoid being detected or blocked	T1027 Obfuscated Files or Information
7	Credential Access	Steal usernames, passwords, tickets, hashes	T1003.001 OS Credential Dumping: LSASS Memory
8	Discovery	Map out hosts, accounts and shares	T1087 Account Discovery

#	Tactic	What the attacker wants	Example technique (with ID)
9	Lateral Movement	Move from one host to another	T1021.001 Remote Services: RDP
10	Collection	Gather the data that is worth stealing	T1560 Archive Collected Data
11	Command and Control	Talk to the compromised host from outside	T1071.001 Application Layer Protocol: Web Protocols
12	Exfiltration	Get the data out of the network	T1041 Exfiltration Over C2 Channel
13	Impact	Destroy, encrypt or disrupt	T1486 Data Encrypted for Impact (ransomware)

How the two are used together

1. An alert fires for `powershell.exe -enc <base64>`.
2. The analyst names the tactic: Execution (and often Defense Evasion, because of the encoding).
3. The analyst names the technique: T1059.001 - PowerShell.
4. The ticket therefore reads: Execution / T1059.001, which immediately tells everyone else what was attempted and what to look for next.

Key points to remember

- Tactic = objective, technique = method - "why" versus "how".
- The T-ID belongs to the technique, never to the tactic.
- One technique can support several tactics; one tactic normally has many techniques.
- Mapping in a real SOC is behaviour-first: describe what you actually observed in the telemetry, then find the technique that matches it.